

PASSING CHORDS

A 5-Step Guide to Upgrading Your Chord Progressions



Introduction from Adam

This is my go-to framework for taking a simple chord progression and making it sound rich, expressive, and full of movement. Each step adds a new layer of harmony that instantly elevates your playing.

Introduction

The Base Progression

🕒 video 1:07

Start with a simple progression that feels clear and grounded. This is the foundation we'll build on — everything that follows is about adding colour and movement without losing that core sound.

Musical notation for the base progression in G major, 4/4 time. The progression consists of four measures: G, C, D, and Em7. The notation shows the treble and bass staves with chord symbols and fingerings.



"Know how the original progression feels first — that's what makes the extra harmony work!"

Step #1

Secondary Dominants

🕒 video 2:08

Introduce dominant chords that resolve into key moments in the progression, like the C and Em.

This creates a stronger sense of pull and makes the harmony feel more directed.

Chord progression: G, G⁷, C, D, B⁷, Em⁷

Adding Inversions



video 3:28

Use inversions on the dominant chords to keep the movement between shapes minimal. This helps everything connect smoothly and avoids big, clunky jumps.

Chord progression: G, G⁷/B, C, D, B⁷/D[#], Em⁷



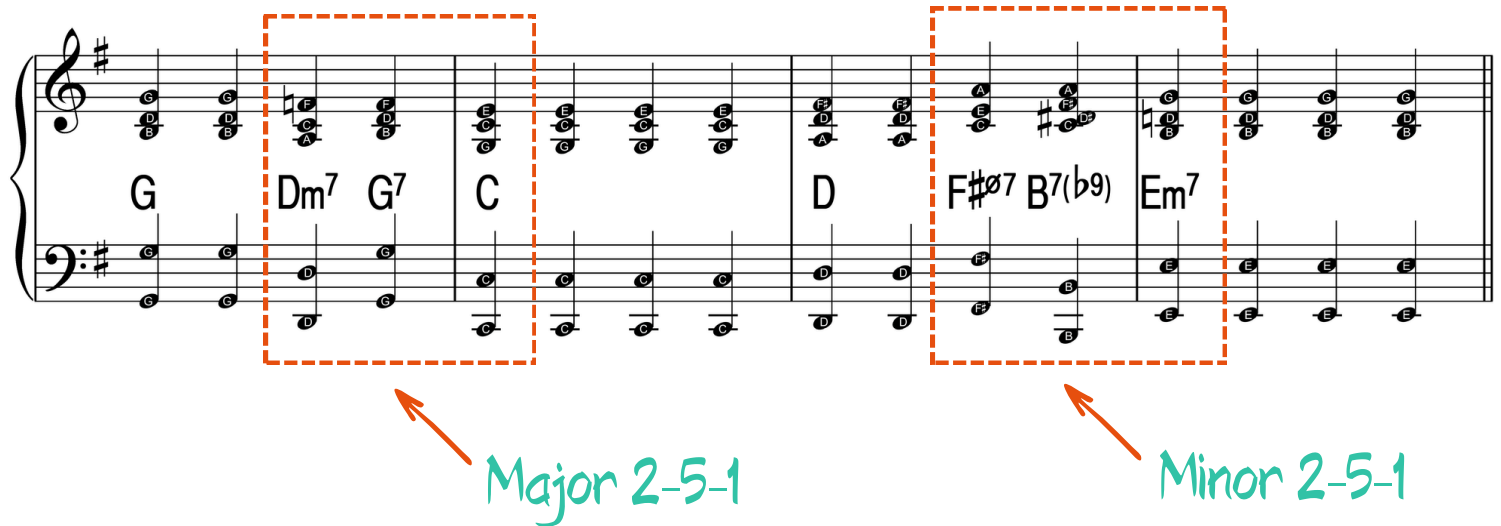
"Tiny chromatic movements between chords can make a progression feel incredibly smooth!"

Step #2

Turning them into 2-5-1's

 video 5:10

Expand the dominants into full 2-5-1 progressions. When resolving to Em, use a half-diminished chord to create a proper minor 2-5-1 sound.



Major 2-5-1

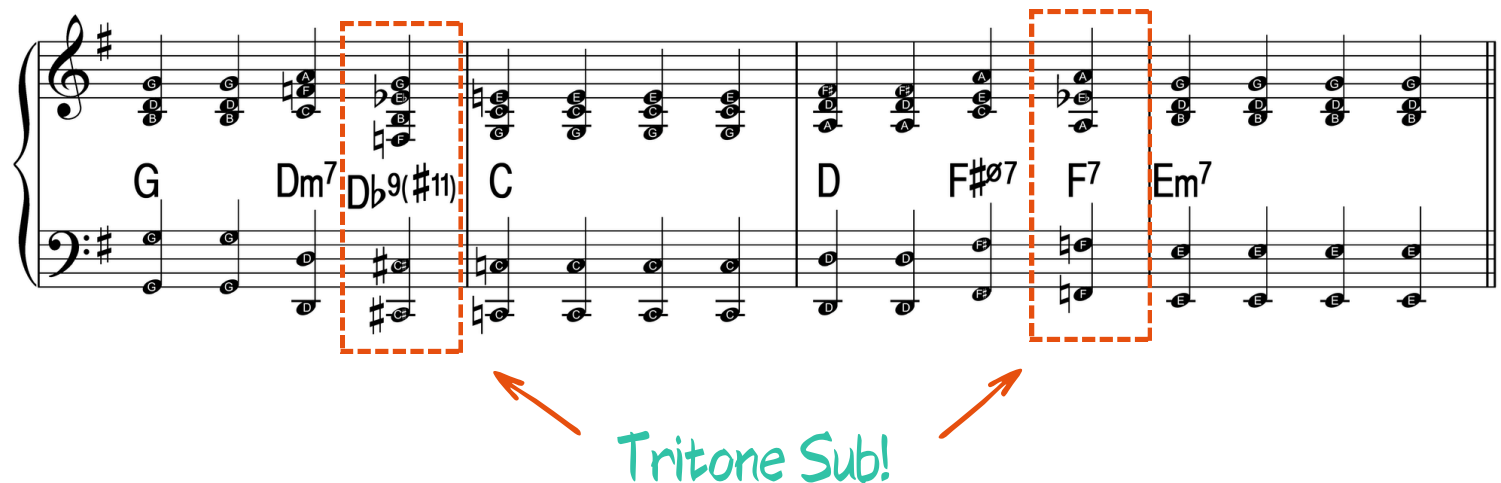
Minor 2-5-1

Step #3

Tritone Substitutions

 video 7:57

Swap the dominant chords for ones a tritone away. This creates a chromatic bass movement and gives the progression a smoother, more modern jazz sound.



Tritone Sub!

Step #4

Walkups



video 10:40

Use stepwise movement in the bass to connect chords. This creates a more hymn-like, flowing sound that feels less jazzy but very musical.

Chords: G, Am⁷, G/B, C, D, A/C[#], B/D[#], Em

Bass line: G₂, A₂, B₂, C₃, D₃, E₃, F₃[#], G₃

Walkup!

Step #5

Passing Diminished



video 13:22

Add diminished chords between movements to create tension and release. These “scrunchy” sounds add colour, especially when combined with chromatic bass motion.

Chords: G, B^{°7}, C, C^{#°7}, D, D^{#°7}, Em⁷

Bass line: G₂, A₂, B₂, C₃, D₃, E₃, F₃[#], G₃

Chromatic walkup!